



SETTLEPATH

Complete Minute-by-Minute Dog Independence Training Guide

Every pen, room/home and secure outdoor session now includes one clear cue for every minute - from first calm separation through future one-hour goals.

 Pen plans

 Room and home plans

 Secure outdoor plans

Updated 30 July 2026 · 52 graded sessions · 1027 minute cues

How to use this guide

Start at the dog's real level

Choose a plan the dog can manage without escalating. A manually chosen higher plan becomes the new baseline only after you actually train it.

Two calm results move up

Two scores of 4 or 5 on the same plan move up. Two scores of 1 or 2 move down. Mixed results or a score of 3 repeat the same plan.

Keep departures ordinary

Use one calm cue. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions. Calmness should feel normal rather than like a performance.

Monitor hidden distress

For real out-of-sight or home departures, use video or audio whenever possible. Quiet pacing, trembling, scanning or abandoning food still count as distress.

Stop before panic

Do not complete a timer while barking, pacing, scratching or escape attempts are escalating. Return calmly and shorten the next attempt.

Practical needs come first

Toileting, sleep, age, medical comfort, water, temperature and safe surroundings matter more than finishing a planned session.

Important: This is a graded training aid, not a diagnosis or a replacement for veterinary or qualified behaviour support. Seek professional help for panic, self-injury, destructive escape attempts, persistent toileting, heavy drooling, refusal of food, or distress that does not improve with easier practice.

Calmness score

1 - Escalating

Cannot settle, panic signs, frantic attempts to escape, or distress keeps increasing.

2 - Frequently distressed

Repeated barking, pacing or difficulty recovering even though brief pauses occur.

3 - Mixed but manageable

Some protest or worry, but the dog can still eat, pause and recover with easier repetitions.

4 - Mostly calm

Minor vocalisation may occur, but the dog settles, uses enrichment and recovers readily.

5 - Calm and confident

Relaxed body, calm activity or rest, and no meaningful escalation during the challenge.



Pen / enclosed safe area

26 graded sessions. Every session below contains one clear instruction for every minute.

1. **Pen 1 of 26** - Safe and Calm Beside the Pen
No planned full absence · 10 minutes
2. **Pen 2 of 26** - Small Distance Changes
No planned full absence · 10 minutes
3. **Pen 3 of 26** - Moving Around the Room
No planned full absence · 10 minutes
4. **Pen 4 of 26** - Extended Calm With You Nearby
No planned full absence · 15 minutes
5. **Pen 5 of 26** - The Distance Ladder
No planned full absence · 15 minutes
6. **Pen 6 of 26** - First Disappear-and-Reappear Practice
Target: 3 seconds · 10 minutes
7. **Pen 7 of 26** - Movement Plus First Absences
Target: 3 seconds · 15 minutes
8. **Pen 8 of 26** - Normal Household Activity
Target: 5 seconds · 10 minutes
9. **Pen 9 of 26** - Short Predictable Absences
Target: 10 seconds · 15 minutes
10. **Pen 10 of 26** - Mixed Short Absences
Target: 10 seconds · 10 minutes
11. **Pen 11 of 26** - Unpredictable Normal-Life Practice
Target: 15 seconds · 15 minutes
12. **Pen 12 of 26** - Bridge to 30 Seconds
Target: 20 seconds · 15 minutes
13. **Pen 13 of 26** - First Full 30 Seconds
Target: 30 seconds · 10 minutes
14. **Pen 14 of 26** - Steady 45-Second Absence
Target: 45 seconds · 12 minutes
15. **Pen 15 of 26** - One-Minute Independence
Target: 1 minute · 15 minutes
16. **Pen 16 of 26** - Ninety Seconds Out of Sight
Target: 1 minute 30 seconds · 15 minutes
17. **Pen 17 of 26** - Two-Minute Calm
Target: 2 minutes · 18 minutes
18. **Pen 18 of 26** - Three-Minute Routine
Target: 3 minutes · 20 minutes
19. **Pen 19 of 26** - Five-Minute Independence
Target: 5 minutes · 25 minutes
20. **Pen 20 of 26** - Eight-Minute Household Absence
Target: 8 minutes · 30 minutes
21. **Pen 21 of 26** - Ten-Minute Calm Alone Time
Target: 10 minutes · 30 minutes
22. **Pen 22 of 26** - Fifteen-Minute Independence
Target: 15 minutes · 35 minutes
23. **Pen 23 of 26** - Twenty-Minute Independence
Target: 20 minutes · 40 minutes
24. **Pen 24 of 26** - Thirty-Minute Independence
Target: 30 minutes · 50 minutes
25. **Pen 25 of 26** - Forty-Five-Minute Independence
Target: 45 minutes · 65 minutes
26. **Pen 26 of 26** - One-Hour Independence
Target: 60 minutes · 75 minutes



Room / home departures

18 graded sessions. Every session below contains one clear instruction for every minute.

1. **Home 1 of 18** - Settle in a Chosen Safe Room
No planned full absence · 8 minutes
2. **Home 2 of 18** - Calm Behind a Baby Gate
Target: 10 seconds · 9 minutes
3. **Home 3 of 18** - First Room Exit and Return
Target: 10 seconds · 9 minutes
4. **Home 4 of 18** - Closed Door for 30 Seconds
Target: 30 seconds · 9 minutes
5. **Home 5 of 18** - One Minute in Another Room
Target: 1 minute · 9 minutes
6. **Home 6 of 18** - Three-Minute Room Separation
Target: 3 minutes · 11 minutes
7. **Home 7 of 18** - Five-Minute Room Routine
Target: 5 minutes · 13 minutes
8. **Home 8 of 18** - Departure Cue Practice
No planned full absence · 8 minutes
9. **Home 9 of 18** - Front Door Exit for 10 Seconds
Target: 10 seconds · 9 minutes
10. **Home 10 of 18** - Front Door Exit for 30 Seconds
Target: 30 seconds · 9 minutes
11. **Home 11 of 18** - One Minute Outside the Home
Target: 1 minute · 9 minutes
12. **Home 12 of 18** - Three Minutes Outside the Home
Target: 3 minutes · 11 minutes
13. **Home 13 of 18** - Five Minutes Outside the Home
Target: 5 minutes · 13 minutes
14. **Home 14 of 18** - Ten Minutes Home Alone
Target: 10 minutes · 18 minutes
15. **Home 15 of 18** - Twenty Minutes Home Alone
Target: 20 minutes · 28 minutes
16. **Home 16 of 18** - Thirty Minutes Home Alone
Target: 30 minutes · 38 minutes
17. **Home 17 of 18** - Forty-Five Minutes Home Alone
Target: 45 minutes · 53 minutes
18. **Home 18 of 18** - One Hour Home Alone
Target: 60 minutes · 68 minutes



Secure private outdoor area

8 graded sessions. Every session below contains one clear instruction for every minute.

1. **Outdoor 1 of 8** - Relax Outdoors While You Stay Visible

No planned full absence · 8 minutes

2. **Outdoor 2 of 8** - Step Indoors for 10 Seconds

Target: 10 seconds · 9 minutes

3. **Outdoor 3 of 8** - Thirty Seconds Outdoors Without You

Target: 30 seconds · 9 minutes

4. **Outdoor 4 of 8** - One Minute Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 1 minute · 9 minutes

5. **Outdoor 5 of 8** - Three Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 3 minutes · 11 minutes

6. **Outdoor 6 of 8** - Five Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 5 minutes · 13 minutes

7. **Outdoor 7 of 8** - Ten Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 10 minutes · 18 minutes

8. **Outdoor 8 of 8** - Twenty Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 20 minutes · 28 minutes



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 1 OF 26

Safe and Calm Beside the Pen

No planned full absence · Full session: 10 minutes

Best for

your dog still cries regularly, but can eat and settle when you stay close.

Goal

Teach them that the pen is safe even when you are present but not entertaining them.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Place your dog in the pen after a toilet break. Sit directly beside the pen, turned slightly sideways. Reward / adjust: Drop 1 piece of kibble for any quiet pause, sniffing, sitting or looking away from you.
Minute 2	Do: Remain beside the pen. Keep your hands to yourself and avoid eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward two or three calm moments. Do not reward every second.
Minute 3	Do: Shift your chair or body about half a metre away. Reward / adjust: If they stays quiet for 3-5 seconds, calmly place kibble into the pen.
Minute 4	Do: Stay at the half-metre distance. Stand up once, then sit down again. Reward / adjust: Reward after you sit if they remained calm or became quiet quickly.
Minute 5	Do: Walk one step away and immediately return to your seat. Reward / adjust: Reward a quiet pause after the movement. Make the next repetition smaller if barking increases.
Minute 6	Do: Sit quietly and do something neutral, such as looking at a book or your phone. Reward / adjust: Reward one or two settled behaviours, especially lying down or engaging with their toy.
Minute 7	Do: Stand beside your chair for 5 seconds, then sit again. Reward / adjust: Drop kibble only while they is quiet, even if the quiet pause lasts one second.
Minute 8	Do: Take two slow steps away, pause briefly, then return to the chair. Reward / adjust: Reward the first quiet moment after you return.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 9	Do: Return to sitting beside the pen and allow an easy minute. Reward / adjust: Give one calm reward, then reduce food so they practises settling without constant feeding.
Minute 10	Do: Finish with 20-30 seconds of calm beside the pen. Open the pen during a quiet pause. Reward / adjust: Release them quietly. Avoid an excited greeting that makes leaving the pen the biggest reward.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 2 OF 26

Small Distance Changes

No planned full absence · Full session: 10 minutes

Best for

your dog manages Level 1 with brief whining rather than escalating crying.

Goal

Help them cope while you move between beside the pen and a few steps away.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Start beside the pen for an easy success. Reward / adjust: Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Do: Move one metre away and sit down. Reward / adjust: Reward after 5-10 seconds of calm. Return to deliver the kibble, then move away again.
Minute 3	Do: Alternate between sitting beside the pen and one metre away. Reward / adjust: Reward calm transitions, not only lying down.
Minute 4	Do: Stand up, take three slow steps, and return. Reward / adjust: Reward a pause in crying. If they remained quiet, wait a little longer before rewarding.
Minute 5	Do: Sit one to two metres away for the full minute. Reward / adjust: Give one or two pieces of kibble during calm behaviour.
Minute 6	Do: Walk past the pen once without stopping, then sit down farther away. Reward / adjust: Reward after you are seated if they is calm.
Minute 7	Do: Move closer for an easier repetition, but do not interact through the bars. Reward / adjust: Reward relaxed body language or quiet engagement with a toy.
Minute 8	Do: Move two metres away, stand for 5-10 seconds, then return to your chair. Reward / adjust: Reward only after a quiet pause.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 9	Do: Sit at the easier distance and ignore them politely. Reward / adjust: Allow them to discover that calmness does not always produce immediate attention.
Minute 10	Do: End beside the pen, then release during a quiet moment. Reward / adjust: Use one final piece of kibble inside the pen before opening it.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 3 OF 26

Moving Around the Room

No planned full absence · Full session: 10 minutes

Best for

your dog can cope with you sitting one to two metres away.

Goal

Teach them that ordinary movement does not mean they must follow you.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Begin seated beside the pen for 30 seconds, then stand. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm pause before moving.
Minute 2	Do: Walk slowly around the room while remaining visible. Reward / adjust: Approach and drop kibble after 10-15 seconds of calm.
Minute 3	Do: Pick up or put down one harmless household item. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the small noise or movement.
Minute 4	Do: Sit across the room for 20-30 seconds, then stand again. Reward / adjust: Reward only once during this minute unless they is finding it difficult.
Minute 5	Do: Walk past the pen twice without stopping. Reward / adjust: After the second pass, reward a quiet pause.
Minute 6	Do: Pause near a doorway but remain fully visible. Reward / adjust: Reward if they watches without escalating.
Minute 7	Do: Return nearer for an easier minute and sit quietly. Reward / adjust: Reward relaxed behaviour, then allow a short food-free period.
Minute 8	Do: Walk to the far side of the room, pause for 5 seconds, and return. Reward / adjust: Reward the first quiet moment after you return.
Minute 9	Do: Repeat a mixture of sitting, standing and walking. Reward / adjust: Use unpredictable rewards so they is not waiting for food after every movement.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Finish with an easy seated position. Release calmly. Reward / adjust: Open the pen after 1-2 seconds of quiet if possible.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 4 OF 26

Extended Calm With You Nearby

No planned full absence · Full session: 15 minutes

Best for

your dog can complete the easiest 10-minute sessions but is not ready for many disappearances.

Goal

Increase total session length without greatly increasing difficulty.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Settle your dog after toileting. Sit beside the pen. Reward / adjust: Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Do: Remain beside them without eye contact or conversation. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sitting, sniffing or lying down.
Minute 3	Do: Move half a metre away. Reward / adjust: Reward after 5 seconds of calm.
Minute 4	Do: Sit quietly and reduce food delivery. Reward / adjust: One calm reward at most.
Minute 5	Do: Stand, take one step away, and sit again. Reward / adjust: Reward a quiet pause.
Minute 6	Do: Move one metre away for 20-30 seconds. Reward / adjust: Return to deliver kibble, then move away again.
Minute 7	Do: Come closer for an easy recovery minute. Reward / adjust: Reward settled behaviour.
Minute 8	Do: Stand beside the pen without interacting. Reward / adjust: Reward if they remains calm while you are upright.
Minute 9	Do: Walk two slow steps away and return. Reward / adjust: Reward after calmness.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Sit one metre away and look occupied. Reward / adjust: Allow a food-free stretch.
Minute 11	Do: Walk once around the room while visible. Reward / adjust: Reward when you return to your chair.
Minute 12	Do: Remain close for a recovery minute. Reward / adjust: One small reward for calmness.
Minute 13	Do: Move one metre away again. Reward / adjust: Reward after a slightly longer quiet period.
Minute 14	Do: Sit beside the pen but continue ignoring politely. Reward / adjust: Do not make the ending obvious or exciting.
Minute 15	Do: Give one final calm reward and release during quietness. Reward / adjust: End neutrally.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 5 OF 26

The Distance Ladder

No planned full absence · Full session: 15 minutes

Best for

your dog can stay calm with you nearby for 15 minutes.

Goal

Practise several distances while keeping you visible.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Start beside the pen. Reward / adjust: Reward a calm start.
Minute 2	Do: Move half a metre away. Reward / adjust: Reward once.
Minute 3	Do: Move one metre away. Reward / adjust: Reward after 5-10 seconds of quiet.
Minute 4	Do: Return closer for an easy minute. Reward / adjust: Reward recovery.
Minute 5	Do: Move two metres away and sit. Reward / adjust: Reward once during calmness.
Minute 6	Do: Stand at the same distance, then sit again. Reward / adjust: Reward calm response to the change.
Minute 7	Do: Walk across the room and return to the two-metre position. Reward / adjust: Reward after you are seated.
Minute 8	Do: Move beside the pen for recovery without interacting. Reward / adjust: Minimal food.
Minute 9	Do: Move to the far side of the room for 10-20 seconds. Reward / adjust: Reward if manageable.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Walk past the pen without stopping. Reward / adjust: Reward later, not immediately every time.
Minute 11	Do: Sit two metres away and remain boring. Reward / adjust: Allow a food-free settling period.
Minute 12	Do: Move closer, then farther again. Reward / adjust: Reward a calm transition.
Minute 13	Do: Walk a small circle around the room. Reward / adjust: Reward after a quiet pause.
Minute 14	Do: Return to an easy distance. Reward / adjust: One final calm reward.
Minute 15	Do: Release quietly during a calm moment. Reward / adjust: Avoid an excited greeting.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 6 OF 26

First Disappear-and-Reappear Practice

Target: 3 seconds · Full session: 10 minutes

Best for

your dog stays manageable while you walk around the room.

Goal

Introduce extremely short moments when you are out of sight.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Start beside the pen and reward calmness. Reward / adjust: Give one easy success before any disappearance.
Minute 2	Do: Walk around the room while remaining visible. Reward / adjust: Reward once after a calm stretch.
Minute 3	Do: Step partly behind the doorway for 1 second, then reappear. Reward / adjust: Return calmly and reward a quiet pause. Repeat only two or three times.
Minute 4	Do: Remain visible and sit one to two metres away. Reward / adjust: Use this as a recovery minute. Reward once if calm.
Minute 5	Do: Disappear for 1-2 seconds, reappear, then continue walking normally. Reward / adjust: Reward after quietness; do not rush directly to the pen every time.
Minute 6	Do: Do three easy visible movements. Reward / adjust: Reward the easiest calm repetition.
Minute 7	Do: Disappear for 2-3 seconds once or twice. Reward / adjust: If they barks, wait for a tiny pause when safe, return, reward, and reduce the next absence.
Minute 8	Do: Sit nearby without interaction. Reward / adjust: Allow them to settle without constant food.
Minute 9	Do: Mix one 1-second disappearance with visible walking. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness unpredictably.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: End with an easy visible minute and release calmly. Reward / adjust: Finish before they becomes tired or frustrated.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 7 OF 26

Movement Plus First Absences

Target: 3 seconds · Full session: 15 minutes

Best for

your dog manages visible distance changes and some 1-3 second disappearances.

Goal

Blend normal movement with very brief out-of-sight repetitions.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Start beside the pen. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness.
Minute 2	Do: Walk slowly around the room. Reward / adjust: Reward once.
Minute 3	Do: Step out of sight for 1 second twice. Reward / adjust: Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Do: Sit one metre away for recovery. Reward / adjust: One reward at most.
Minute 5	Do: Complete a small visible household action. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement.
Minute 6	Do: Disappear for 2 seconds once or twice. Reward / adjust: Reduce difficulty if barking escalates.
Minute 7	Do: Remain visible and sit across the room. Reward / adjust: Allow a food-free stretch.
Minute 8	Do: Walk past the doorway but do not disappear. Reward / adjust: Reward calm response to the cue.
Minute 9	Do: Disappear for 2-3 seconds once. Reward / adjust: Reward quietness after returning.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Come nearer for recovery without touching them. Reward / adjust: Reward settled behaviour.
Minute 11	Do: Walk around normally while visible. Reward / adjust: One unpredictable reward.
Minute 12	Do: Disappear for 1 second, then later for 3 seconds. Reward / adjust: Keep both returns calm.
Minute 13	Do: Sit one to two metres away. Reward / adjust: Allow them to settle.
Minute 14	Do: Finish with visible, easy movement. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm moment.
Minute 15	Do: Release quietly. Reward / adjust: End before overtired crying begins.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 8 OF 26

Normal Household Activity

Target: 5 seconds · Full session: 10 minutes

Best for

your dog handles 1-3 second disappearances with only mild protest.

Goal

Make pen time feel like part of ordinary life rather than a formal exercise.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Settle them with a safe toy while you sit nearby. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm start.
Minute 2	Do: Walk around and complete a tiny household task. Reward / adjust: Reward after 15-20 seconds of calm.
Minute 3	Do: Disappear for 2-4 seconds, then return without making eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward a quiet pause after you are back.
Minute 4	Do: Sit across the room and ignore them politely. Reward / adjust: One calm reward at most.
Minute 5	Do: Walk past the pen, touch the door handle, and remain visible. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness around the departure cue.
Minute 6	Do: Disappear for 3-5 seconds once or twice. Reward / adjust: Reduce to 1-2 seconds if the crying becomes sharper or more continuous.
Minute 7	Do: Return to visible movement and an easier distance. Reward / adjust: Reward recovery and calm engagement with the toy.
Minute 8	Do: Carry out another small normal task while visible. Reward / adjust: Reward after a longer quiet stretch.
Minute 9	Do: Mix one short disappearance with two easy visible movements. Reward / adjust: Reward only one of the three repetitions.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Sit calmly near the pen, then release during quietness. Reward / adjust: End neutrally, without a big reunion.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 9 OF 26

Short Predictable Absences

Target: 10 seconds · Full session: 15 minutes

Best for

your dog can recover quickly after 2-3 second disappearances.

Goal

Build absences of approximately 3-10 seconds while mixing in many easy repetitions.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Start close and easy. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm pause.
Minute 2	Do: Move around while visible. Reward / adjust: Reward once.
Minute 3	Do: Disappear for 3 seconds once. Reward / adjust: Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Do: Sit nearby for recovery. Reward / adjust: Minimal food.
Minute 5	Do: Disappear for 4-5 seconds once. Reward / adjust: If they copes, reward calmly.
Minute 6	Do: Complete two visible movements. Reward / adjust: Reward one of them.
Minute 7	Do: Disappear for 3 seconds, return, and remain visible. Reward / adjust: Reward after calmness.
Minute 8	Do: Sit farther away for a quiet minute. Reward / adjust: Allow independent settling.
Minute 9	Do: Disappear for 5-7 seconds once. Reward / adjust: Halve the next absence if crying becomes continuous.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Come closer for recovery. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness, not excitement.
Minute 11	Do: Walk past the pen and touch the door handle. Reward / adjust: Reward calm response to the cue.
Minute 12	Do: Disappear for 3 seconds, then later for 6-8 seconds. Reward / adjust: Keep the second repetition optional if they is tired.
Minute 13	Do: Remain visible and boring. Reward / adjust: No reward unless needed.
Minute 14	Do: Finish with an easy visible minute. Reward / adjust: One final calm reward.
Minute 15	Do: Release during a quiet pause. Reward / adjust: End neutrally.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 10 OF 26

Mixed Short Absences

Target: 10 seconds · Full session: 10 minutes

Best for

your dog usually settles quickly after 3-5 second absences.

Goal

Build flexibility with different distances and brief absences without making every repetition harder.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Start close and easy. Reward / adjust: Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Do: Move around the room while visible. Reward / adjust: Reward once.
Minute 3	Do: Disappear for 3 seconds, then remain visible for the rest of the minute. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after returning.
Minute 4	Do: Sit one metre away for an easy recovery minute. Reward / adjust: Minimal food; encourage independent settling.
Minute 5	Do: Disappear for 5-8 seconds once. Reward / adjust: If calm, reward after returning. If they cries continuously, halve the next absence.
Minute 6	Do: Complete two easy visible movements. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm repetition.
Minute 7	Do: Disappear for 3 seconds, return, then later disappear for 6-10 seconds. Reward / adjust: Keep your return calm and ordinary.
Minute 8	Do: Stay visible but farther away. Reward / adjust: Reward a settled posture or quiet play.
Minute 9	Do: Mix one easy 1-second absence and one harder 5-10 second absence. Reward / adjust: Reward only after quietness; do not increase both distance and duration at once.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Finish close to the pen and release calmly. Reward / adjust: End while they is still coping, not after a final difficult test.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA • PEN 11 OF 26

Unpredictable Normal-Life Practice

Target: 15 seconds • Full session: 15 minutes

Best for

your dog manages 5-10 second absences without escalating.

Goal

Prevent them from predicting exactly when you leave, return or reward.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Start beside the pen and then move away. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm start.
Minute 2	Do: Perform a normal visible task. Reward / adjust: Reward after a longer calm stretch.
Minute 3	Do: Disappear for 5 seconds once. Reward / adjust: Return calmly; reward quietness.
Minute 4	Do: Sit across the room. Reward / adjust: No reward unless they settles particularly well.
Minute 5	Do: Walk past the pen twice without stopping. Reward / adjust: Reward later, not immediately.
Minute 6	Do: Disappear for 8-12 seconds once. Reward / adjust: Reduce to 3-5 seconds if needed.
Minute 7	Do: Return and continue the task rather than going directly to them. Reward / adjust: Reward after they is quiet.
Minute 8	Do: Sit nearby for recovery. Reward / adjust: One small reward.
Minute 9	Do: Disappear for 3 seconds, then remain visible. Reward / adjust: Easy repetition.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Complete a quiet household task for the full minute. Reward / adjust: Reward at the end if calm.
Minute 11	Do: Disappear for 10-15 seconds once. Reward / adjust: Only attempt if the previous minutes were manageable.
Minute 12	Do: Return and sit one to two metres away. Reward / adjust: Allow them to settle without immediate food.
Minute 13	Do: Mix visible walking with one 5-second absence. Reward / adjust: Reward unpredictably.
Minute 14	Do: Finish close and calm. Reward / adjust: One final reward inside the pen.
Minute 15	Do: Release quietly during calmness. Reward / adjust: No big reunion.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 12 OF 26

Bridge to 30 Seconds

Target: 20 seconds · Full session: 15 minutes

Best for

your dog usually recovers quickly after 10-15 second disappearances.

Goal

Practise flexible 10-20 second absences before beginning the dedicated 30-second ladder.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Begin close and easy. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness.
Minute 2	Do: Walk around while visible. Reward / adjust: Reward once.
Minute 3	Do: Disappear for 8-10 seconds. Reward / adjust: Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Do: Sit nearby for recovery. Reward / adjust: Minimal food.
Minute 5	Do: Disappear for 15-20 seconds once. Reward / adjust: Return earlier if distress escalates.
Minute 6	Do: Stay visible and perform an easy task. Reward / adjust: Reward recovery.
Minute 7	Do: Disappear for 5 seconds only. Reward / adjust: This easier repetition prevents constant escalation.
Minute 8	Do: Sit across the room for the full minute. Reward / adjust: Allow independent settling.
Minute 9	Do: Disappear for approximately 15-20 seconds once. Reward / adjust: Attempt this only while they remains manageable; return earlier if crying escalates.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 10	Do: Return and remain visible. Reward / adjust: Reward after quietness.
Minute 11	Do: Complete two easy visible movements. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm response.
Minute 12	Do: Repeat an easier 8-12 second disappearance rather than adding a longer final test. Reward / adjust: End with confidence. The next stage contains the first dedicated 30-second attempt.
Minute 13	Do: Return and sit near the pen for recovery. Reward / adjust: Give one calm reward.
Minute 14	Do: Keep the final minute easy and visible. Reward / adjust: Do not add a last difficult test.
Minute 15	Do: Release quietly during calmness. Reward / adjust: End while they is coping.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if your dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 13 OF 26

First Full 30 Seconds

Target: 30 seconds · Full session: 10 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the 10-20 second bridge stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 30 sec without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 15 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Begin the main challenge. Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. for up to 30 seconds, then return calmly within this minute. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 10 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 8	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 9	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 10	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



Steady 45-Second Absence

Target: 45 seconds · Full session: 12 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 45 sec without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 22 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Begin the main challenge. Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. for up to 45 seconds, then return calmly within this minute. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 7	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 8	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 9	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 15 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 10	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 11	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 12	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



One-Minute Independence

Target: 1 minute · Full session: 15 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 min without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 1. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 7	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 8	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 9	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 10	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 11	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 12	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 20 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 13	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 14	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 15	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 16 OF 26

Ninety Seconds Out of Sight

Target: 1 minute 30 seconds · Full session: 15 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 min 30 sec without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 45 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 2. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 2. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 8	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 9	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 10	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 11	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 12	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 30 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 13	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 14	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 15	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 17 OF 26

Two-Minute Calm

Target: 2 minutes · Full session: 18 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 2 min without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 1 minute and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 2. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 2. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 8	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 9	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 10	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 11	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 12	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 13	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 14	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 15	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 40 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 16	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 17	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 18	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



Three-Minute Routine

Target: 3 minutes · Full session: 20 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 3 min without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 1 minute 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 3. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 3. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 3. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 9	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 10	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 11	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 12	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 13	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 14	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 15	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 16	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 17	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 1 minute, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 18	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 19	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 20	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 19 OF 26

Five-Minute Independence

Target: 5 minutes · Full session: 25 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 5 min without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 2 minutes 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 5. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 5. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 5. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 4 of 5. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 5 of 5. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 11	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 12	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 13	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 14	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 15	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 16	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 17	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 18	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 19	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 20	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 21	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 22	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 1 minute 40 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 23	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 24	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 25	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 20 OF 26

Eight-Minute Household Absence

Target: 8 minutes · Full session: 30 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 8 min without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 4 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 8. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 8. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 8. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 4 of 8. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 5 of 8. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 6 of 8. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 7 of 8. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 8 of 8. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 14	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 15	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 16	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 17	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 18	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 19	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 20	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 21	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 22	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 23	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 24	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 25	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 26	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 27	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 2 minutes 40 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 28	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 29	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 30	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 21 OF 26

Ten-Minute Calm Alone Time

Target: 10 minutes · Full session: 30 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 10 min without escalating distress.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 4 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 5 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 6 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 7 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 8 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 9 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 10 of 10. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 16	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 17	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 18	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 19	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 20	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 21	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 22	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 23	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 24	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 25	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 26	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 27	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 3 minutes 20 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 28	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 29	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 30	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 22 OF 26

Fifteen-Minute Independence

Target: 15 minutes · Full session: 35 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 15 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 4 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 5 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 6 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 7 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 8 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 9 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 10 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 11 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 12 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 13 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 14 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 15 of 15. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 21	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 22	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 23	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 24	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 25	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 26	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 27	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 28	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 29	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 30	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 31	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 32	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 33	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 34	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 35	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 23 OF 26

Twenty-Minute Independence

Target: 20 minutes · Full session: 40 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 20 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 4 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 5 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 6 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 7 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 8 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 9 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 10 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 11 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 12 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 13 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 14 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 15 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 16 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 21	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 17 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 22	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 18 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 23	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 19 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 24	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 20 of 20. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 25	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 26	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 27	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 28	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 29	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 30	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 31	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 32	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 33	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 34	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 35	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 36	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 37	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 38	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 39	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 40	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 24 OF 26

Thirty-Minute Independence

Target: 30 minutes · Full session: 50 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 30 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 4 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 5 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 6 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 7 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 8 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 9 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 10 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 11 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 12 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 13 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 14 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 15 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 16 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 21	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 17 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 22	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 18 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 23	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 19 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 24	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 20 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 25	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 21 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 26	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 22 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 27	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 23 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 28	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 24 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 29	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 25 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 30	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 26 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 31	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 27 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 32	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 28 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 33	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 29 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 34	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 30 of 30. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 35	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 36	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 37	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 38	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 39	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 40	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 41	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 42	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 43	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 44	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 45	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 46	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 47	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 48	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 49	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 50	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 25 OF 26

Forty-Five-Minute Independence

Target: 45 minutes · Full session: 65 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 45 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 4 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 5 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 6 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 7 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 8 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 9 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 10 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 11 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 12 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 13 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 14 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 15 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 16 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 21	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 17 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 22	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 18 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 23	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 19 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 24	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 20 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 25	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 21 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 26	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 22 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 27	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 23 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 28	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 24 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 29	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 25 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 30	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 26 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 31	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 27 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 32	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 28 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 33	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 29 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 34	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 30 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 35	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 31 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 36	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 32 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 37	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 33 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 38	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 34 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 39	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 35 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 40	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 36 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 41	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 37 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 42	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 38 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 43	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 39 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 44	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 40 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 45	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 41 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 46	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 42 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 47	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 43 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 48	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 44 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 49	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 45 of 45. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 50	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 51	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 52	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 53	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 54	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 55	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 56	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 57	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 58	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 59	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 60	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 61	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 62	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 63	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 64	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 65	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



PEN / ENCLOSED SAFE AREA · PEN 26 OF 26

One-Hour Independence

Target: 60 minutes · Full session: 75 minutes

Best for

your dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal

Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 hr without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase, such as 'settle time', then keep departures and returns ordinary.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity first
- Comfortable, ventilated pen or enclosed safe area
- Water when appropriate and one familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor for real out-of-sight practice

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the pen or enclosed safe area. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the pen or enclosed safe area. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk normally, touch the doorway and say the calm cue once before the absence. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Move out of sight while your dog remains in the pen or enclosed safe area. Start the timer. Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 1 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 2 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 3 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 4 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 5 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 6 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 7 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 8 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 9 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 10 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 11 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 12 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 13 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 14 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 15 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 16 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 21	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 17 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 22	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 18 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 23	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 19 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 24	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 20 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 25	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 21 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 26	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 22 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 27	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 23 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 28	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 24 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 29	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 25 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 30	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 26 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 31	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 27 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 32	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 28 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 33	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 29 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 34	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 30 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 35	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 31 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 36	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 32 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 37	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 33 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 38	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 34 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 39	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 35 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 40	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 36 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 41	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 37 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 42	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 38 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 43	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 39 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 44	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 40 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 45	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 41 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 46	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 42 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 47	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 43 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 48	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 44 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 49	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 45 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 50	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 46 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 51	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 47 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 52	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 48 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 53	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 49 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 54	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 50 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 55	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 51 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 56	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 52 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 57	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 53 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 58	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 54 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 59	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 55 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 60	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 56 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 61	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 57 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 62	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 58 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 63	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 59 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 64	Do: Remain out of sight. This is challenge minute 60 of 60. Use the monitor to check for a loose body, resting, sniffing or calm use of the safe toy. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 65	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 66	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 67	Do: Sit at an easy distance and allow a food-free settling period. Reward / adjust: If they is calm, simply let calmness continue.
Minute 68	Do: Check that the dog remains comfortable and that the training area is still safe. Reward / adjust: Make a note of any subtle signs such as pacing, panting, scanning, freezing or abandoning food.
Minute 69	Do: Remain visible and quietly unavailable while your dog settles again. Reward / adjust: Reward one relaxed choice, such as lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 70	Do: Complete a small normal household movement without starting another difficult absence. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not excited following.
Minute 71	Do: Return calmly and continue a normal low-key activity near the training area. Reward / adjust: Wait for calm recovery before offering one small reward.
Minute 72	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 73	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 74	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 75	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.



Settle in a Chosen Safe Room

No planned full absence · Full session: 8 minutes

Best for

Cannot yet relax away from constant attention.

Goal

Build calm independence in the room that will later be used for alone time.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare one quiet dog-safe room with a bed, water and a familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Remove cables, bins, plants and anything the dog could swallow or damage.
Minute 2	Do: Enter the room with your dog. Scatter a few pieces of kibble and sit close to the resting area. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing and choosing to stay in the room.
Minute 3	Do: Move one metre away while remaining in the room. Reward / adjust: Reward a quiet pause or relaxed body position.
Minute 4	Do: Walk slowly to the doorway, touch the frame and return to your seat. Reward / adjust: If they follows, calmly reset without closing the door.
Minute 5	Do: Stand in the doorway for 5-10 seconds while remaining fully visible. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after you return to the room.
Minute 6	Do: Step one foot beyond the doorway, immediately step back and resume a normal activity. Reward / adjust: Reward the first calm pause; make the movement smaller if vocalising increases.
Minute 7	Do: Sit near the doorway but become politely unavailable for the full minute. Reward / adjust: Allow your dog to settle without constant food or attention.
Minute 8	Do: Finish with an easy calm period inside the room and leave the room together. Reward / adjust: Keep the ending neutral and record what helped them settle.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Calm Behind a Baby Gate

Target: 10 seconds · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Can settle with the person nearby.

Goal

Introduce a visible barrier without fully disappearing.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Prepare the safe room and place a secure baby gate across the doorway. Keep the main door open. Reward / adjust: Check that the gate height and gaps are safe for the dog.
Minute 2	Do: Stay on the same side of the gate as your dog while they settles with a familiar item. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm choice.
Minute 3	Do: Step to the other side of the gate for 3 seconds while remaining visible, then return. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery.
Minute 4	Do: Repeat the visible gate crossing for 5 seconds. Reward / adjust: If they jumps at the gate, shorten the next repetition.
Minute 5	Do: Stay on the other side of the gate for up to 10 seconds while facing slightly away. Reward / adjust: Return before continuous barking or frantic gate contact.
Minute 6	Do: Return to the dog's side for a quiet recovery minute. Reward / adjust: Reward lying down, sniffing or returning to the enrichment item.
Minute 7	Do: Cross the gate again and briefly move one step out of view for 1-2 seconds. Reward / adjust: Return calmly and reward a quiet pause.
Minute 8	Do: Do one easy visible repetition shorter than the best attempt. Reward / adjust: Confidence matters more than matching the maximum time.
Minute 9	Do: Finish together in the room, then open the gate during calm behaviour. Reward / adjust: Avoid a big reunion at the gate.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



First Room Exit and Return

Target: 10 seconds · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Can remain calm behind a gate for a few seconds.

Goal

Teach that a person can step out of the room and immediately return.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Prepare the dog-safe room and settle your dog while the doorway remains open. Reward / adjust: Begin after toileting and with one familiar safe item.
Minute 2	Do: Walk to the doorway and return without leaving. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness around your movement.
Minute 3	Do: Step completely out of the room for 1 second, reappear and continue normally. Reward / adjust: Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Do: Remain in the room for an easy recovery minute. Reward / adjust: Use one reward at most and allow independent settling.
Minute 5	Do: Exit for 3 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: If vocalising becomes sharp, use 1 second again.
Minute 6	Do: Walk around inside the room while visible. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery rather than following.
Minute 7	Do: Exit for 5 seconds, then later repeat for up to 10 seconds. Reward / adjust: Return before panic and keep both reunions ordinary.
Minute 8	Do: Sit just inside the room for an easy final minute. Reward / adjust: Reward relaxed behaviour once.
Minute 9	Do: End calmly and record the longest comfortable room exit. Reward / adjust: Do not finish with the hardest repetition.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Closed Door for 30 Seconds

Target: 30 seconds · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Can cope with very short room exits.

Goal

Introduce a closed door in tiny, predictable repetitions.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk to the doorway, say the calm cue once and leave the room without a long goodbye. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 15 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Begin the main challenge. Leave the chosen room and close the door only if the previous open-door stage is comfortable. for up to 30 seconds, then return calmly within this minute. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 10 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 8	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 9	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



One Minute in Another Room

Target: 1 minute · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Recovers well after 30-second room separations.

Goal

Build a calm one-minute room separation.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk to the doorway, say the calm cue once and leave the room without a long goodbye. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Leave the chosen room and close the door only if the previous open-door stage is comfortable. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 1. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 20 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 8	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 9	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Three-Minute Room Separation

Target: 3 minutes · Full session: 11 minutes

Best for

Can relax for about one minute.

Goal

Extend room separation while preserving easy recovery periods.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk to the doorway, say the calm cue once and leave the room without a long goodbye. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 1 minute 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Leave the chosen room and close the door only if the previous open-door stage is comfortable. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 3. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 3. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 3. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 1 minute, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 9	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 10	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 11	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Five-Minute Room Routine

Target: 5 minutes · Full session: 13 minutes

Best for

Can cope for several minutes in another room.

Goal

Make short separation part of normal household life.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Walk to the doorway, say the calm cue once and leave the room without a long goodbye. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 2 minutes 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Leave the chosen room and close the door only if the previous open-door stage is comfortable. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 4 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 5 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 1 minute 40 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 11	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 12	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 13	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Departure Cue Practice

No planned full absence · Full session: 8 minutes

Best for

Reacts to keys, shoes, bags or the front door.

Goal

Teach that departure cues do not always predict a long absence.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen safe room with a familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness before touching any departure cue.
Minute 2	Do: Touch the keys, then put your hand down and continue a normal activity. Reward / adjust: Reward only if they remains relaxed or recovers quickly.
Minute 3	Do: Pick up the keys for 5 seconds, put them down and sit again. Reward / adjust: If the dog becomes tense, return to simply touching the keys.
Minute 4	Do: Put on shoes, then remove them without leaving. Reward / adjust: Reward relaxed behaviour after the cue.
Minute 5	Do: Pick up a bag or jacket, walk around the room and put it down. Reward / adjust: Keep the movement slow and ordinary.
Minute 6	Do: Touch the front-door handle, open the door slightly, close it and remain inside. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness once you have moved away from the door.
Minute 7	Do: Combine two cues, such as shoes and keys, but complete a normal indoor activity instead of leaving. Reward / adjust: Use a smaller cue if your dog begins pacing, panting or following closely.
Minute 8	Do: Finish with one very easy room-separation repetition and a neutral return. Reward / adjust: The goal is that cues stop predicting a difficult absence every time.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Front Door Exit for 10 Seconds

Target: 10 seconds · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Can remain in a safe room while the person moves around the home.

Goal

Introduce stepping outside the home for a few seconds.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Begin the main challenge. Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. for up to 10 seconds, then return calmly within this minute. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 3 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 8	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 9	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Front Door Exit for 30 Seconds

Target: 30 seconds · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Recovers easily after 10-second exits.

Goal

Build calm, repeated 30-second exits.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 15 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Begin the main challenge. Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. for up to 30 seconds, then return calmly within this minute. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 10 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 8	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 9	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



One Minute Outside the Home

Target: 1 minute · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Can cope with short front-door exits.

Goal

Build one minute of true home-alone practice.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 1. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 20 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 8	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 9	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Three Minutes Outside the Home

Target: 3 minutes · Full session: 11 minutes

Best for

Can stay calm for about one minute.

Goal

Extend true absence gradually to three minutes.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 1 minute 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 3. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 3. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 3. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 1 minute, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 9	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 10	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 11	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Five Minutes Outside the Home

Target: 5 minutes · Full session: 13 minutes

Best for

Can relax during several short exits.

Goal

Build a reliable five-minute home-alone routine.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 2 minutes 30 seconds and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 4 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 5 of 5. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 1 minute 40 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 11	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 12	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 13	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Ten Minutes Home Alone

Target: 10 minutes · Full session: 18 minutes

Best for

Can settle for about five minutes.

Goal

Reach ten minutes without increasing difficulty on every repetition.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 4 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 5 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 6 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 7 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 8 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 9 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 10 of 10. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 3 minutes 20 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 16	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 17	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 18	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Twenty Minutes Home Alone

Target: 20 minutes · Full session: 28 minutes

Best for

Can relax for ten minutes.

Goal

Extend to twenty minutes with one monitored challenge attempt.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 4 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 5 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 6 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 7 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 8 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 9 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 10 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 11 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 12 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 13 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 14 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 15 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 16 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 21	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 17 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 22	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 18 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 23	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 19 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 24	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 20 of 20. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 25	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 26	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 27	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 28	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Thirty Minutes Home Alone

Target: 30 minutes · Full session: 38 minutes

Best for

Can remain settled for twenty minutes.

Goal

Build a stable half-hour routine.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 4 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 5 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 6 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 7 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 8 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 9 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 10 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 11 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 12 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 13 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 14 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 15 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 16 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 21	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 17 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 22	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 18 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 23	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 19 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 24	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 20 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 25	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 21 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 26	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 22 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 27	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 23 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 28	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 24 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 29	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 25 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 30	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 26 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 31	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 27 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 32	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 28 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 33	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 29 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 34	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 30 of 30. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 35	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 36	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 37	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 38	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



Forty-Five Minutes Home Alone

Target: 45 minutes · Full session: 53 minutes

Best for

Can cope reliably for thirty minutes.

Goal

Extend to forty-five minutes without rushing.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 4 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 5 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 6 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 7 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 8 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 9 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 10 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 11 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 12 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 13 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 14 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 15 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 16 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 21	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 17 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 22	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 18 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 23	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 19 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 24	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 20 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 25	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 21 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 26	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 22 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 27	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 23 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 28	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 24 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 29	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 25 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 30	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 26 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 31	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 27 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 32	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 28 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 33	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 29 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 34	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 30 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 35	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 31 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 36	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 32 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 37	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 33 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 38	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 34 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 39	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 35 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 40	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 36 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 41	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 37 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 42	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 38 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 43	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 39 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 44	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 40 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 45	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 41 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 46	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 42 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 47	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 43 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 48	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 44 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 49	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 45 of 45. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 50	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 51	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 52	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 53	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



One Hour Home Alone

Target: 60 minutes · Full session: 68 minutes

Best for

Can remain relaxed for forty-five minutes.

Goal

Reach a future one-hour goal using calm, monitored practice.

Calm cue: Use one short, calm phrase such as 'back soon'. Avoid emotional goodbyes and excited reunions.

Quick setup checklist

- Toilet opportunity and age-appropriate exercise first
- A dog-safe room with bed, water and no accessible hazards
- One familiar safe enrichment item
- Camera or audio monitor before true home departures

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Offer a toilet break and prepare the chosen dog-safe room. Remove hazards, provide a comfortable bed and choose one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Begin only when your dog is awake, comfortable and reasonably calm.
Minute 2	Do: Settle your dog in the chosen dog-safe room. Stay nearby without entertaining them and wait for a calm pause. Reward / adjust: Reward quiet sniffing, sitting, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Minute 3	Do: Complete one mild departure cue, say the calm cue once and leave through the front door. Reward / adjust: Keep the cue ordinary. If the cue alone causes worry, repeat an easier cue-only plan before leaving.
Minute 4	Do: Complete one easy warm-up absence of about 5 minutes and return calmly. Reward / adjust: Reward calm recovery. If this warm-up is difficult, stop and use the previous plan.
Minute 5	Do: Step through the front door and remain close enough to return immediately while monitoring your dog. Start the timer. Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 1 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 6	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 2 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 3 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 8	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 4 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 9	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 5 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 10	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 6 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 11	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 7 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 12	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 8 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 13	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 9 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 14	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 10 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 15	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 11 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 16	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 12 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 17	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 13 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 18	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 14 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 19	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 15 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 20	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 16 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 21	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 17 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 22	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 18 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 23	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 19 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 24	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 20 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 25	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 21 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 26	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 22 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 27	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 23 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 28	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 24 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 29	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 25 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 30	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 26 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 31	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 27 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 32	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 28 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 33	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 29 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 34	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 30 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 35	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 31 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 36	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 32 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 37	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 33 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 38	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 34 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 39	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 35 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 40	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 36 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 41	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 37 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 42	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 38 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 43	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 39 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 44	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 40 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 45	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 41 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 46	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 42 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 47	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 43 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 48	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 44 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 49	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 45 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 50	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 46 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 51	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 47 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 52	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 48 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 53	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 49 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 54	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 50 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 55	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 51 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 56	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 52 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 57	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 53 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 58	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 54 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 59	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 55 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 60	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 56 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 61	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 57 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 62	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 58 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 63	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 59 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 64	Do: Remain out of the room or outside the home. This is challenge minute 60 of 60. Use the monitor to check for resting, quiet exploration or calm enrichment use. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait for panic. Return if vocalising becomes continuous, pacing increases, food is abandoned or the dog cannot recover.
Minute 65	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 66	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 67	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 68	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.



SECURE PRIVATE OUTDOOR AREA · OUTDOOR 1 OF 8

Relax Outdoors While You Stay Visible

No planned full absence · Full session: 8 minutes

Best for

Is comfortable in a secure private outdoor area.

Goal

Teach calm settling outdoors without constant interaction.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase such as 'garden settle'. Outdoor practice is optional and must never replace safe home-alone skills.

Quick setup checklist

- Fully enclosed private area with locked gates and no escape gaps
- Safe temperature, shade, clean water and weather protection
- No toxic plants, tools, pools or reachable hazards
- Camera or direct monitoring and immediate ability to return

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Inspect the private outdoor area. Check fences, gates, shade, water, plants, tools, pools and anything that could cause escape or injury. Reward / adjust: Do not train outdoors if the area or weather is unsafe.
Minute 2	Do: Give your dog a toilet opportunity and place a comfortable mat or bed in the shaded resting area. Reward / adjust: Reward choosing the resting area.
Minute 3	Do: Stay close but avoid constant interaction while they explores or uses a safe enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing, lying down or quiet play.
Minute 4	Do: Move two or three metres away while remaining fully visible. Reward / adjust: Return closer if they becomes worried.
Minute 5	Do: Walk toward the house, touch the door and return without going inside. Reward / adjust: Reward the first calm pause after the movement.
Minute 6	Do: Sit in a different outdoor position and become quietly unavailable. Reward / adjust: Allow a food-free settling period if your dog is calm.
Minute 7	Do: Complete one small normal outdoor task while remaining visible. Reward / adjust: Reward calmness after the movement, not barking for attention.
Minute 8	Do: Finish after an easy calm minute. Recheck water, shade and comfort before bringing them inside. Reward / adjust: Keep the reunion low key and record any environmental triggers.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.



SECURE PRIVATE OUTDOOR AREA · OUTDOOR 2 OF 8

Step Indoors for 10 Seconds

Target: 10 seconds · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Can relax outside while the person is visible.

Goal

Introduce a very brief indoor disappearance.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase such as 'garden settle'. Outdoor practice is optional and must never replace safe home-alone skills.

Quick setup checklist

- Fully enclosed private area with locked gates and no escape gaps
- Safe temperature, shade, clean water and weather protection
- No toxic plants, tools, pools or reachable hazards
- Camera or direct monitoring and immediate ability to return

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Inspect the private outdoor area before training. Check every gate and fence, remove hazards, and confirm comfortable weather, shade and clean water. Reward / adjust: Do not begin if the area is not fully secure or if the temperature, wind, rain or noise makes the area unsuitable.
Minute 2	Do: Give your dog a toilet opportunity, then settle them in the outdoor resting area with one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing, lying down or choosing the resting place.
Minute 3	Do: Stay outside but become quietly unavailable. Walk a few steps, sit down and avoid constant eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm moment. If they cannot settle while you are visible, use the previous outdoor plan.
Minute 4	Do: Do an easy warm-up: step indoors or out of view for about 5 seconds, then return calmly. Reward / adjust: Return before distress and check the environment again before the main attempt.
Minute 5	Do: Begin the main challenge. Step indoors or fully out of view while your dog remains in the secure outdoor resting area. for up to 10 seconds, then return calmly within this minute. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 6	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 3 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 8	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 9	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.



SECURE PRIVATE OUTDOOR AREA · OUTDOOR 3 OF 8

Thirty Seconds Outdoors Without You

Target: 30 seconds · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Recovers well after 10-second disappearances.

Goal

Build a calm 30-second outdoor separation.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase such as 'garden settle'. Outdoor practice is optional and must never replace safe home-alone skills.

Quick setup checklist

- Fully enclosed private area with locked gates and no escape gaps
- Safe temperature, shade, clean water and weather protection
- No toxic plants, tools, pools or reachable hazards
- Camera or direct monitoring and immediate ability to return

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Inspect the private outdoor area before training. Check every gate and fence, remove hazards, and confirm comfortable weather, shade and clean water. Reward / adjust: Do not begin if the area is not fully secure or if the temperature, wind, rain or noise makes the area unsuitable.
Minute 2	Do: Give your dog a toilet opportunity, then settle them in the outdoor resting area with one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing, lying down or choosing the resting place.
Minute 3	Do: Stay outside but become quietly unavailable. Walk a few steps, sit down and avoid constant eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm moment. If they cannot settle while you are visible, use the previous outdoor plan.
Minute 4	Do: Do an easy warm-up: step indoors or out of view for about 15 seconds, then return calmly. Reward / adjust: Return before distress and check the environment again before the main attempt.
Minute 5	Do: Begin the main challenge. Step indoors or fully out of view while your dog remains in the secure outdoor resting area. for up to 30 seconds, then return calmly within this minute. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 6	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 10 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 7	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 8	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 9	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.



SECURE PRIVATE OUTDOOR AREA · OUTDOOR 4 OF 8

One Minute Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 1 minute · Full session: 9 minutes

Best for

Can remain settled outside for 30 seconds.

Goal

Extend to one minute while monitored.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase such as 'garden settle'. Outdoor practice is optional and must never replace safe home-alone skills.

Quick setup checklist

- Fully enclosed private area with locked gates and no escape gaps
- Safe temperature, shade, clean water and weather protection
- No toxic plants, tools, pools or reachable hazards
- Camera or direct monitoring and immediate ability to return

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Inspect the private outdoor area before training. Check every gate and fence, remove hazards, and confirm comfortable weather, shade and clean water. Reward / adjust: Do not begin if the area is not fully secure or if the temperature, wind, rain or noise makes the area unsuitable.
Minute 2	Do: Give your dog a toilet opportunity, then settle them in the outdoor resting area with one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing, lying down or choosing the resting place.
Minute 3	Do: Stay outside but become quietly unavailable. Walk a few steps, sit down and avoid constant eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm moment. If they cannot settle while you are visible, use the previous outdoor plan.
Minute 4	Do: Do an easy warm-up: step indoors or out of view for about 30 seconds, then return calmly. Reward / adjust: Return before distress and check the environment again before the main attempt.
Minute 5	Do: Step indoors or fully out of view while your dog remains in the secure outdoor resting area. Start the timer. Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 1 of 1. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 20 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 7	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 8	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 9	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.



SECURE PRIVATE OUTDOOR AREA · OUTDOOR 5 OF 8

Three Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 3 minutes · Full session: 11 minutes

Best for

Can relax for one minute outdoors.

Goal

Build a three-minute outdoor separation.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase such as 'garden settle'. Outdoor practice is optional and must never replace safe home-alone skills.

Quick setup checklist

- Fully enclosed private area with locked gates and no escape gaps
- Safe temperature, shade, clean water and weather protection
- No toxic plants, tools, pools or reachable hazards
- Camera or direct monitoring and immediate ability to return

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Inspect the private outdoor area before training. Check every gate and fence, remove hazards, and confirm comfortable weather, shade and clean water. Reward / adjust: Do not begin if the area is not fully secure or if the temperature, wind, rain or noise makes the area unsuitable.
Minute 2	Do: Give your dog a toilet opportunity, then settle them in the outdoor resting area with one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing, lying down or choosing the resting place.
Minute 3	Do: Stay outside but become quietly unavailable. Walk a few steps, sit down and avoid constant eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm moment. If they cannot settle while you are visible, use the previous outdoor plan.
Minute 4	Do: Do an easy warm-up: step indoors or out of view for about 1 minute 30 seconds, then return calmly. Reward / adjust: Return before distress and check the environment again before the main attempt.
Minute 5	Do: Step indoors or fully out of view while your dog remains in the secure outdoor resting area. Start the timer. Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 1 of 3. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 2 of 3. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 7	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 3 of 3. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 8	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 1 minute, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 9	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 10	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 11	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.



SECURE PRIVATE OUTDOOR AREA · OUTDOOR 6 OF 8

Five Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 5 minutes · Full session: 13 minutes

Best for

Can settle outdoors for several minutes.

Goal

Reach five minutes without increasing difficulty too quickly.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase such as 'garden settle'. Outdoor practice is optional and must never replace safe home-alone skills.

Quick setup checklist

- Fully enclosed private area with locked gates and no escape gaps
- Safe temperature, shade, clean water and weather protection
- No toxic plants, tools, pools or reachable hazards
- Camera or direct monitoring and immediate ability to return

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Inspect the private outdoor area before training. Check every gate and fence, remove hazards, and confirm comfortable weather, shade and clean water. Reward / adjust: Do not begin if the area is not fully secure or if the temperature, wind, rain or noise makes the area unsuitable.
Minute 2	Do: Give your dog a toilet opportunity, then settle them in the outdoor resting area with one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing, lying down or choosing the resting place.
Minute 3	Do: Stay outside but become quietly unavailable. Walk a few steps, sit down and avoid constant eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm moment. If they cannot settle while you are visible, use the previous outdoor plan.
Minute 4	Do: Do an easy warm-up: step indoors or out of view for about 2 minutes 30 seconds, then return calmly. Reward / adjust: Return before distress and check the environment again before the main attempt.
Minute 5	Do: Step indoors or fully out of view while your dog remains in the secure outdoor resting area. Start the timer. Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 1 of 5. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 2 of 5. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 7	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 3 of 5. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 8	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 4 of 5. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 9	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 5 of 5. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 10	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 1 minute 40 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.
Minute 11	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 12	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 13	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.



SECURE PRIVATE OUTDOOR AREA · OUTDOOR 7 OF 8

Ten Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 10 minutes · Full session: 18 minutes

Best for

Can remain calm for five minutes outdoors.

Goal

Build a monitored ten-minute outdoor routine.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase such as 'garden settle'. Outdoor practice is optional and must never replace safe home-alone skills.

Quick setup checklist

- Fully enclosed private area with locked gates and no escape gaps
- Safe temperature, shade, clean water and weather protection
- No toxic plants, tools, pools or reachable hazards
- Camera or direct monitoring and immediate ability to return

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Inspect the private outdoor area before training. Check every gate and fence, remove hazards, and confirm comfortable weather, shade and clean water. Reward / adjust: Do not begin if the area is not fully secure or if the temperature, wind, rain or noise makes the area unsuitable.
Minute 2	Do: Give your dog a toilet opportunity, then settle them in the outdoor resting area with one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing, lying down or choosing the resting place.
Minute 3	Do: Stay outside but become quietly unavailable. Walk a few steps, sit down and avoid constant eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm moment. If they cannot settle while you are visible, use the previous outdoor plan.
Minute 4	Do: Do an easy warm-up: step indoors or out of view for about 5 minutes, then return calmly. Reward / adjust: Return before distress and check the environment again before the main attempt.
Minute 5	Do: Step indoors or fully out of view while your dog remains in the secure outdoor resting area. Start the timer. Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 1 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 2 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 7	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 3 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 8	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 4 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 9	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 5 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 10	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 6 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 11	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 7 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 12	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 8 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 13	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 9 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 14	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 10 of 10. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 15	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 3 minutes 20 seconds, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 16	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 17	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 18	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.



SECURE PRIVATE OUTDOOR AREA · OUTDOOR 8 OF 8

Twenty Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Target: 20 minutes · Full session: 28 minutes

Best for

Can remain calm for ten minutes and the environment is exceptionally safe.

Goal

Use a future twenty-minute outdoor goal only when weather, security and supervision are suitable.

Calm cue: Use one calm phrase such as 'garden settle'. Outdoor practice is optional and must never replace safe home-alone skills.

Quick setup checklist

- Fully enclosed private area with locked gates and no escape gaps
- Safe temperature, shade, clean water and weather protection
- No toxic plants, tools, pools or reachable hazards
- Camera or direct monitoring and immediate ability to return

Minute-by-minute instructions

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 1	Do: Inspect the private outdoor area before training. Check every gate and fence, remove hazards, and confirm comfortable weather, shade and clean water. Reward / adjust: Do not begin if the area is not fully secure or if the temperature, wind, rain or noise makes the area unsuitable.
Minute 2	Do: Give your dog a toilet opportunity, then settle them in the outdoor resting area with one safe familiar enrichment item. Reward / adjust: Reward calm sniffing, lying down or choosing the resting place.
Minute 3	Do: Stay outside but become quietly unavailable. Walk a few steps, sit down and avoid constant eye contact. Reward / adjust: Reward one calm moment. If they cannot settle while you are visible, use the previous outdoor plan.
Minute 4	Do: Do an easy warm-up: step indoors or out of view for about 5 minutes, then return calmly. Reward / adjust: Return before distress and check the environment again before the main attempt.
Minute 5	Do: Step indoors or fully out of view while your dog remains in the secure outdoor resting area. Start the timer. Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 1 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 6	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 2 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 7	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 3 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 8	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 4 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 9	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 5 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 10	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 6 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 11	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 7 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 12	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 8 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 13	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 9 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 14	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 10 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 15	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 11 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 16	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 12 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 17	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 13 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 18	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 14 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 19	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 15 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 20	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 16 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 21	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 17 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 22	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 18 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 23	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 19 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 24	Do: Remain indoors or out of view. This is challenge minute 20 of 20. Check the camera or listen for relaxed behaviour, and also check shade, water, weather and gate security. Return calmly near the end of this minute when the target is complete. Reward / adjust: Do not wait through escalating barking, escape attempts, heat stress or frantic behaviour. Return immediately and make the next attempt much shorter.
Minute 25	Do: Do one easier consolidation repetition of about 5 minutes, or remain visible if the main attempt was challenging. Reward / adjust: Choose the easier option. The purpose is confidence, not achieving another maximum.

Minute	Instruction and adjustment
Minute 26	Do: Offer a brief toilet or water check if needed, then return to the safe resting area for an easy finish. Reward / adjust: Practical needs always take priority over completing the planned timer.
Minute 27	Do: Stay nearby and allow a quiet recovery period without excited attention. Reward / adjust: Reward settled body language once, then keep the reunion neutral.
Minute 28	Do: Finish with a calm, ordinary ending. Record the actual comfortable absence and the calmness score. Reward / adjust: End on the easiest successful behaviour available; do not add a final surprise challenge.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

Guidance sources

The progression principles in this guide are informed by established animal-welfare guidance: increase separation gradually, shorten attempts when worry appears, use positive enrichment, monitor for hidden distress, and ensure outdoor security, shade, water and weather protection.

1. Dogs Trust - How to help your dog get used to spending time alone

Build time apart gradually, pair it with positive enrichment, monitor the dog and shorten the next attempt if anxiety appears.

<https://www.dogstrust.org.uk/dog-advice/training/home/time-alone>

2. Dogs Trust - Separation anxiety: leaving the room

Practise brief out-of-sight periods, increase time gradually and use a camera to check that the dog remains relaxed.

<https://www.dogstrust.org.uk/dog-advice/training/unwanted-behaviours/separation-anxiety>

3. RSPCA - How to train your dog to stay home alone

Use gradual alone-time training and periodic video checks for hidden signs such as pacing, trembling or quiet whining.

<https://www.rspca.org.uk/adviceandwelfare/pets/dogs/training/leftalone>

4. Blue Cross - Preventing separation anxiety in puppies

Move at the puppy's pace and return to the last comfortable duration whenever worry appears.

<https://www.bluecross.org.uk/advice/dog/behaviour-and-training/preventing-separation-anxiety-in-puppies>

5. RSPCA - Keeping dogs outside

Outdoor time requires shelter, water, security and protection from weather, loneliness and distress.

<https://www.rspca.org.uk/adviceandwelfare/pets/dogs/environment/livingoutside>

6. RSPCA - Caring for dogs in hot weather

Dogs need constant access to shade and clean water in warm weather.

<https://www.rspca.org.uk/adviceandwelfare/seasonal/summer/dogs>